

Meeting in the middle

Work had already begun by the mid-1860s to connect the EIR line from Calcutta to the GIPR line from Bombay. The 1,180-km distance from Calcutta to Jubbulpore went via Allahabad and the railway route from Howrah (Calcutta) to Naini Junction (Allahabad) had already been completed. Work on the Allahabad–Jubbulpore section – a distance of about 360 km – was completed in 1867. The line opened for general traffic on 1 August 1867, and the route closely followed the Mirzapore road. The route to the west was designed to go from Jubbulpore to Itarsi (in modern-day Madhya Pradesh), another major junction in central India.

One of the most daunting construction works done on this line was building the rail bridge over the Narmada River. *The Imperial Gazetteer of India*, quoting the report of the administration of the Central Provinces, mentions that large quantities of building material came from exhuming the remains of temple edifices and ancient cities found in shapeless masses covered with earth that had accumulated over the centuries.

Epidemics and other woes

Engineers involved in the construction of the line faced numerous problems, including difficulties in the supply of girders and good-quality sleepers, not to mention the inhospitable, hilly terrain, and thick, mosquito-infested jungles. Outbreaks of epidemics, such as cholera and smallpox, were common and caused a large number of deaths among the construction labourers. Mr Smith, the executive officer-in-charge, died of cholera even as the inspector of works, Mr Boast, succumbed to smallpox.

In a letter dated 14 August 1869, the chief engineer Robert Maitland Brereton wrote to the GIPR agent that the severity of cholera and smallpox had kept a large number of the usual hands from upper India away from work. As a consequence, labour was imported from Poona and the Deccan districts. He records, “I am satisfied that but for the extraordinary exertions of the engineers and the contractors, it would not have been possible to have had the through line to Jubbulpore before the cold season of 1870–71.” The line from Bombay finally reached Jubbulpore on 8 March 1870.